

FIELD NOTES · THE WEB & ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE

The Open Web in the Age of AI

How search, crawling, and human attention are being reshaped by the fastest platform shift on record.



EDITED BY

Ratty2Tails

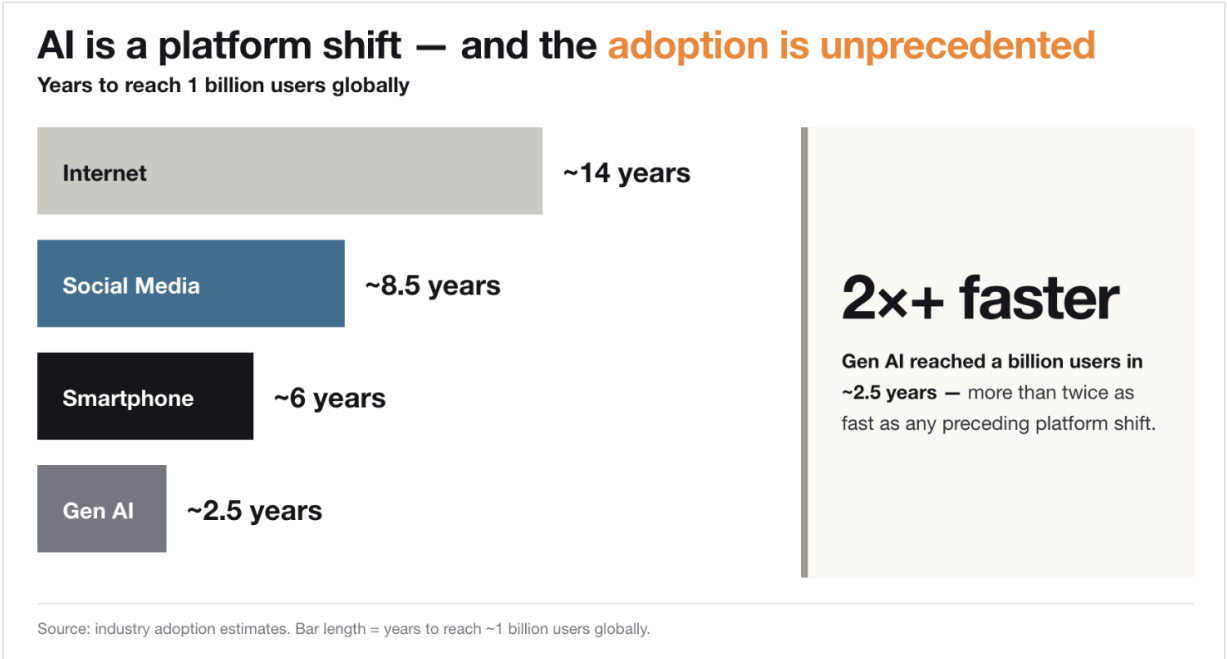
Chronicler of markets, money & machines

Compiled 1 July 2026 · Source data: Cloudflare Radar & Cloudflare network telemetry

The Core Argument: AI Is Fundamentally Changing How the Web Works

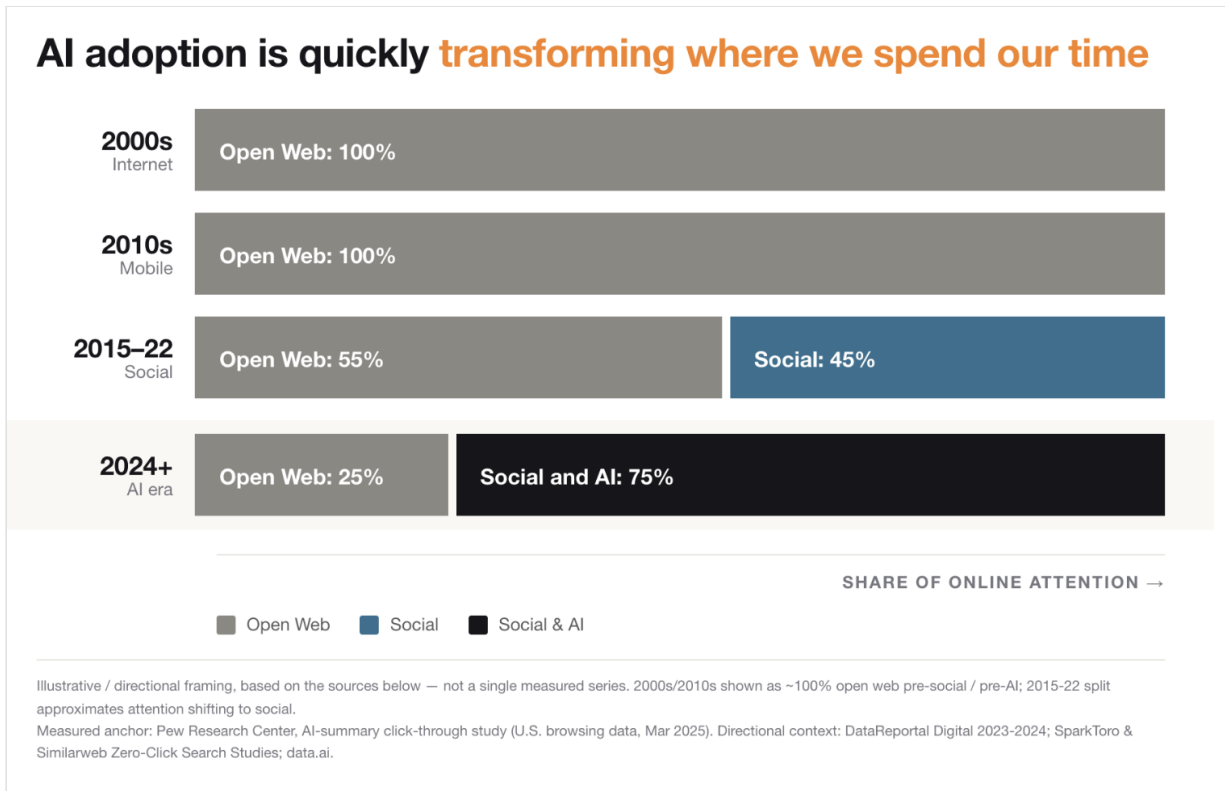
Seven charts, one story: the infrastructure of discovery — search, crawling, referral traffic — is being quietly rewired by AI, even as Google's grip on search itself remains nearly total.

1 Search is still dominated by Google — but the traffic it sends is changing in nature



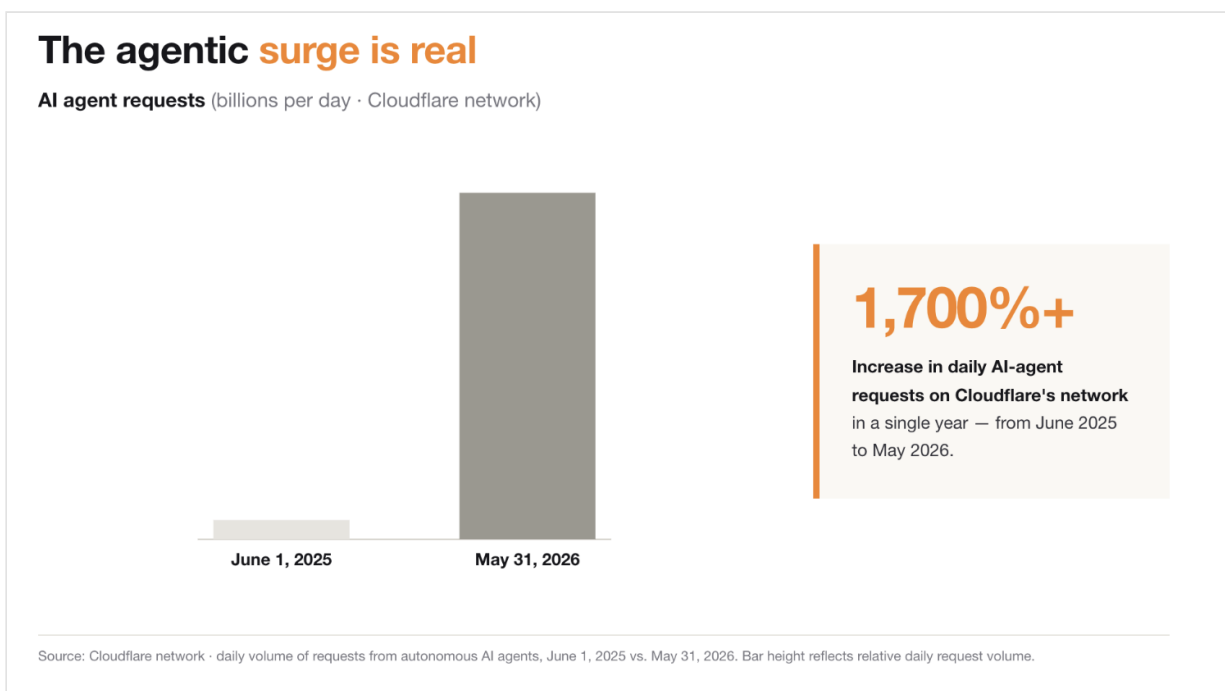
Google accounts for **87.8%** of all referral traffic to sites, dwarfing Bing (3.4%), TikTok (3.2%), and others. Despite AI disruption narratives, Google remains the overwhelming gatekeeper of discovery.

2 Human traffic is falling sharply across every major industry



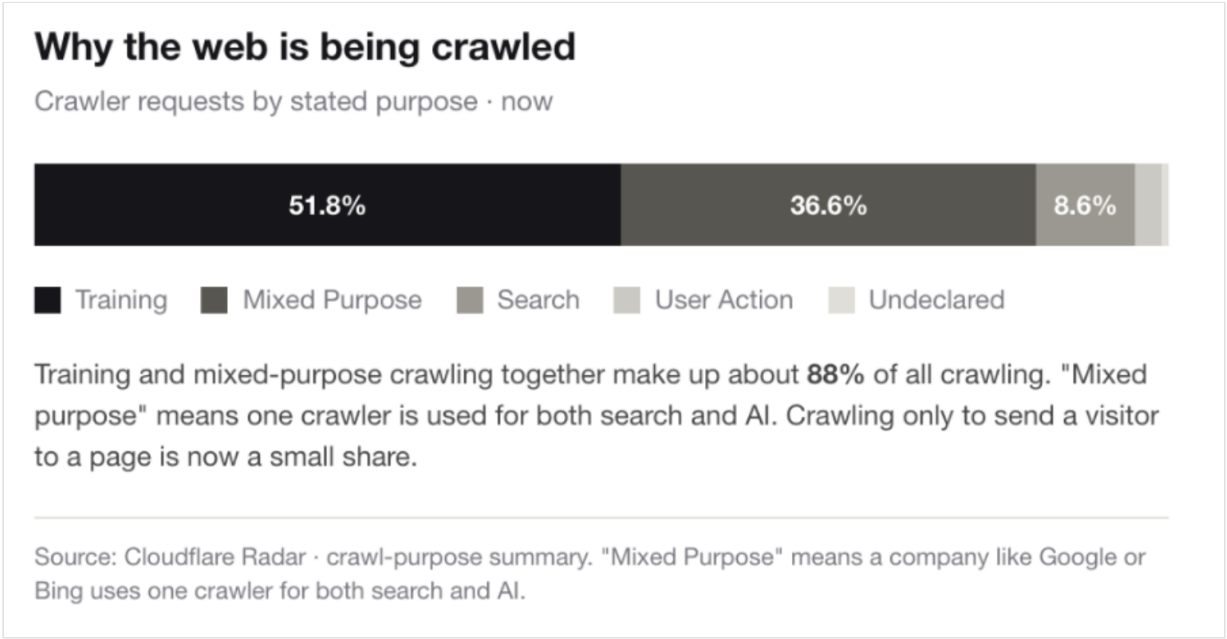
Between June 2025 and April 2026, human (non-bot) traffic dropped **35–40%** across retail, computer software, IT & services, and financial services — a broad, consistent decline rather than an isolated sector issue.

3 Fewer visitors are coming back per page crawled



The ratio of visitors returned per page crawled has worsened from roughly 1:6.5 in early 2025 to **1:9.6** now — meaning crawlers are doing far more work for far fewer actual human visits, a sign that crawling is increasingly disconnected from sending people to sites.

4 Most crawling isn't even about sending users to your site anymore

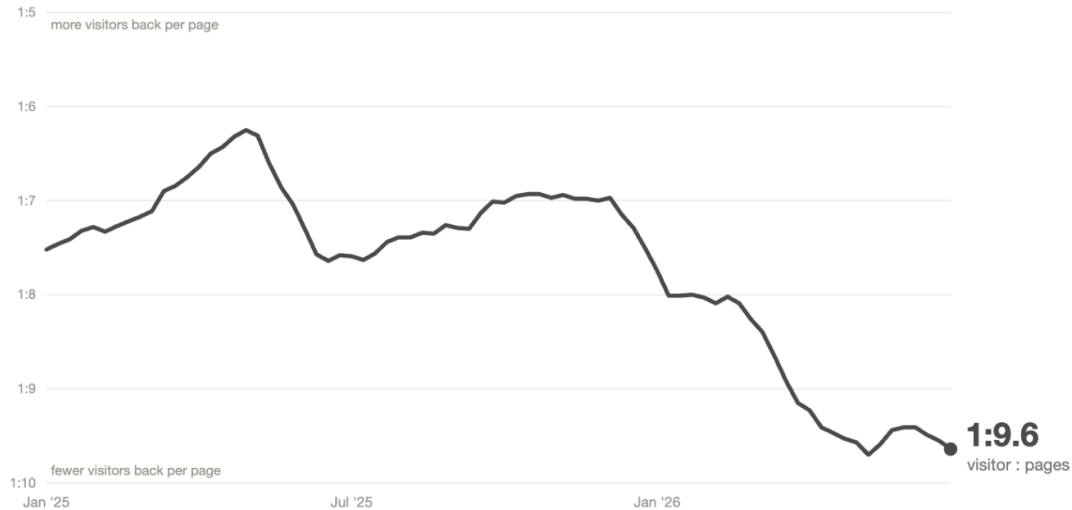


51.8% of crawler requests are for AI training, and another **36.6%** are "mixed purpose" (used for both search and AI). Together that's **~88%** of crawling. Pure search-referral crawling — the kind that sends a human visitor back — is now a small minority.

5 AI agents themselves are surging as web traffic sources

Across all crawlers, fewer and fewer visitors come back per page

Visitors returned per pages crawled, blended across all crawlers · weekly, 5-week average · read as **1 visitor : N pages crawled** — the further the line drops, the more pages crawled for each visitor sent back.



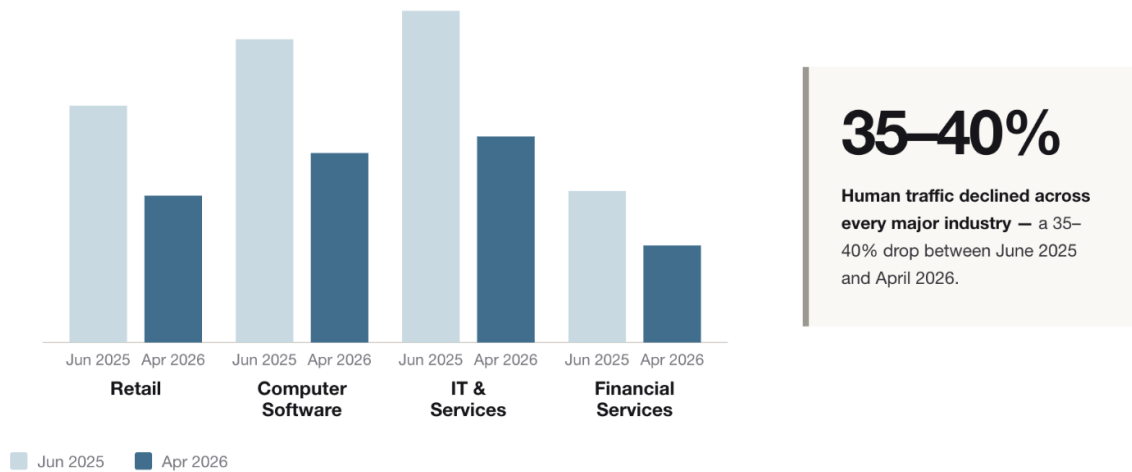
Source: Cloudflare Radar · **blended estimate** computed from the weekly crawl-purpose mix (search / mixed / AI) with representative per-type ratios (~3 search, ~5 mixed, ~1,200 AI), shown as a 5-week average. Axis shows the ratio as **1 : N** (visitors : pages); a lower line = fewer visitors returned per page crawled.

Daily AI-agent requests on Cloudflare's network grew **over 1,700%** between June 2025 and May 2026 — autonomous agents browsing and acting on the web are becoming a major, rapidly growing traffic category.

6 Attention itself is shifting away from the open web

We are seeing **multiple industries** impacted

Absolute human traffic by industry (June 2025 vs. April 2026 comparison)



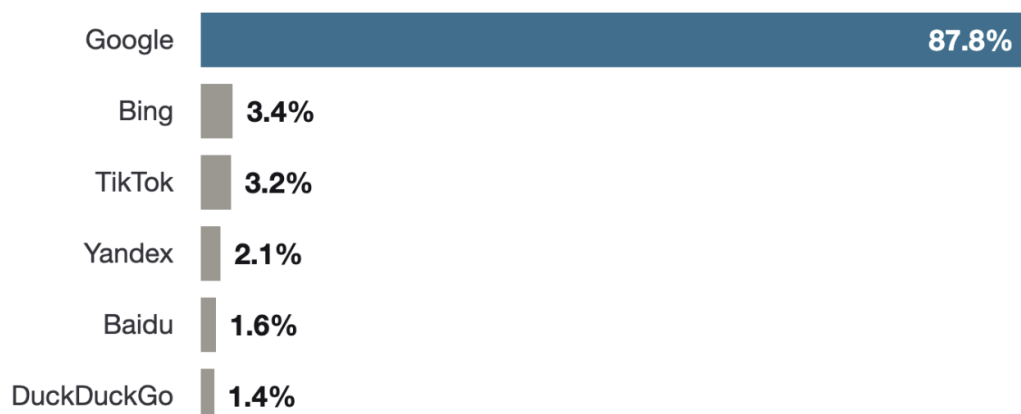
Source: Cloudflare Radar · absolute human (non-bot) requests by industry vertical, indexed to each industry's Jun 2025 level. Bar height reflects relative human traffic; every vertical declined 35–40% over the period.

Historically, the open web captured 100% of online attention (2000s–2010s). Social media eroded that to 55% by 2015–22, and now in the "AI era" (2024+), the open web is estimated to hold just **25%** of attention, with social and AI capturing the rest.

7 AI adoption is happening faster than any previous platform shift

Google sees the searches — and sends **nearly all the referrals**

Share of referral traffic to sites, by source · last 4 weeks



Source: Cloudflare Radar · referral traffic by source. "Google" aggregates Google's search properties.

While the internet took ~14 years and smartphones ~6 years to reach 1 billion users, generative AI got there in roughly **2.5 years** — more than twice as fast as any prior technology shift.

The throughline: AI is restructuring the web's traffic economy. Search still funnels most referrals through Google, but crawling is now overwhelmingly about AI training and mixed-use rather than sending human visitors. Human traffic is declining broadly, AI agents are exploding as a traffic source, and attention overall is migrating away from the open web faster than any past technological transition.



Compiled and edited by **Ratty2Tails** · Source: Cloudflare Radar & Cloudflare network telemetry, June 2025 – May 2026.